

As a base thing, I really enjoy being able to help people. This could be helping somebody learn something new or understand a topic, helping somebody complete a task, and/or just being there to talk to people I know. While “helping people” is a broad theme, it also allows many people with different knowledge bases and skill to work together to solve an issue. Nobody in this world can do everything by themselves, so being able to lighten the load for somebody is what I strive to do. For me, learning computer science skills and coding will help me bridge the gap between people and things they need help with.

The project for my Capstone is an example of how coding can bridge the gap. With the world becoming more technology based, newer generations are more involved in digital media. While I don't like this switch to digitalize everything, it's no doubt the way forward for the world at this point. This project involved working with a community partner, the Office of Sustainability at St Thomas, and making some of their games digitized. They faced 2 major issues with their physical games. First, they had to manually reset after each participant. Second. The games involved one person at a time, so people would walk by or watch and not be involved. The digitization of the games meant that more people would be able to get involved in the event compared to a physical game. We were the first group to digitize a game for the OSI, so we had to figure out how to implement them. This led us to learn how to code a video game, first in GamerMaker with their custom language, then in Phaser using JavaScript. In the end, we were able to create 3 games that the OSI believed could be played at an event. This was a good test of what my current ability to learn new languages from my base in Python and Java, but also a good test of how I would do in a team environment. I now know things I need to work on like better communication with my team but also learned how I should split up work to pace myself on a project based on deadlines.

In order to be able to help others, you need to have knowledge first or be willing to learn new information. Being a student at St Thomas was a way to test my ability to gain knowledge and then apply it in paper and/or projects. An example is the paper for my Psychology class. While it wasn't an in-depth research/study, I believe it was a good steppingstone on how I should learn about new ideas to boost my understanding. The paper was limited to a certain set of topics, so I needed to be able to narrow down to what I would like to learn more about. I was given a two-week time frame to complete the project, so I had to decide when to work on it and still manage my other class's workload. This led me to split up the research in one week and the writing in a separate week. I first reflected on the knowledge I already had with the topic, double checking how valid my knowledge was. While researching, I ended up looking at other papers about the topic. Not all of them were useful, but I was able to gain a broader understanding instead of the sub-topic I narrowed in on. From the papers that were useful, I had to be able to check my understanding of what is being said and being able to pick which sections are useful for me. By being able to properly split my workload over the given time frame, I was less stressed about the paper and able to do well on it. This paper set a good example on the level of research I should do to feel knowledgeable about a topic

When thinking about how I specifically want to be able to use the knowledge gained from St Thomas in the future, it's creating things that will help people rather than harm them. The best way to do is by understanding what the problem is. This means I need to learn who it's affecting and its current impact. From there, I have to be able to research what current things are available and how successful they are. If there are any limitations to the current products, why is it there and can it be changed. Something I dislike is the number of things that are paywalled. While I

understand that people spend time creating something and may want money in return, its always disheartening when something needed/wanted isn't accessible. I wouldn't say you're helping if a reward is expected, so I would aim to create things that anybody could use.

After figuring out what could be changed, I need to be the one to act on it. So many issues are acknowledged but never acted on, so nothing changes. By being the person who starts a change is the first step. I would reach out to people for two reasons. First would be to boost my knowledge. Research can lead to a certain amount of knowledge, but by talking to people who need and would use it, you can create a product that will actually be useful. Second is reaching out to other people for help. An individual can only complete a task so fast, but I can find people who are willing to help, the project can come together a lot faster. Nobody knows how to do everything, so working as a team can shore up any gaps